

THE CULTURAL STIGMA OF “MARD KO DARD NAHI HOTA”: ADDRESSING MALE VICTIMHOOD IN PAKISTAN

By Anaya Awais

"Mard ko Dard Nahi Hota" (Men do not feel pain). It is a trope so deeply embedded in the Pakistani psyche that it serves as both a cultural instruction and a psychological shield.

Yet, behind this lies a stark reality which is essential for our society to acknowledge: pain, when forced into silence, does not vanish—it grows and grows. While Pakistan's public discourse on harassment and abuse has made progress in recent years, this progress has largely been centred on the experiences of women, which is both justified and essential for their empowerment. However, a critical blind spot remains: the male experience of victimization at the hands of women—a reality often erased by our cultural narrative.

To discuss male victimhood is not to underestimate the severity of the violence faced by women; rather, it is to acknowledge the fact that abuse and harassment are not gender-exclusive.

Conversations with numerous individuals claiming to be male victims across major urban centres, including Karachi, Lahore, and Islamabad, reveal a consistent pattern of trauma stemming from female perpetrators. Whether the incident involved sexual coercion, domestic abuse, blackmail, or emotional manipulation, the impact on male survivors shared countless similarities: confusion, shame, a paralysing fear of ridicule, and many more sentiments that made them undermine their worth and their respect (commonly addressed in the patriarchal society of Pakistan as "izzat").

This silence isn't some accident. It is the product of a culture that insists men have to be bulletproof.

When society equates emotional distress with weakness—exclusively for the male gender—disclosure becomes a social liability. Many survivors regard their experiences as moral failings, believing that because they did not physically resist or "act like a man," their victimization is somehow illegitimate.

Public perception often considers male victimization as anecdotal, yet the available evidence suggests a more nuanced reality. Studies conducted in Nai Abadi Chakra, Rawalpindi, on domestic dynamics in Pakistan have consistently documented high levels of psychological and physical aggression against men.¹ Similarly, research conducted in District Lower Dir, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, found that nearly 99 per cent of surveyed married men had experienced some form of psychological aggression, ranging from humiliation to coercive control within their marital relationships.²

At the same time, official national data demonstrate that reported cases are heavily skewed towards women, particularly in workplace harassment. According to the Federal Ombudsman Secretariat for Protection Against Harassment (FOSPAH), 3,571 workplace harassment complaints were filed between 2011 and 2023, of which 2,716 (76%) were submitted by women and 855 (24%) by men.³ While these statistics indicate that women comprise the majority of reported complainants, they should not be interpreted as evidence that men rarely experience harassment. Reporting patterns are themselves influenced by social stigma. A national survey found that 65% of Pakistanis believe men rarely report harassment, while fear of ridicule, perceived threats to masculinity, and social shame remain among the leading barriers preventing male victims from seeking help.⁴ Consequently, the comparatively lower number of reported male cases is likely to reflect underreporting rather than an absence of victimization.

Globally, the picture is equally concerning. Research on male survivors of sexual assault by female perpetrators indicates strong associations with post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD), chronic anxiety, depression, and sleep disturbances.⁵ These figures are not mere statistics; they represent a silent mental health crisis affecting individuals whom our current support systems remain ill-equipped to assist.

On paper, Pakistan's constitutional framework guarantees equality before the law. Article 25 of the Constitution explicitly states that all citizens are equal before the law, are entitled to equal protection of the law, and that there shall be no discrimination on the basis of sex, while permitting special provisions for the protection of women and children.⁶ Provincial domestic violence legislation likewise recognises emotional and psychological abuse as punishable offences.⁷

Yet, there is a significant gap between the letter of the law and its application. Current reporting mechanisms are built almost exclusively through a female-centric lens; while women's reports of abuse are rightfully taken with urgency and seriousness, the same infrastructure frequently fails men. When a man attempts to report abuse or seek counselling, he is often met with scepticism, ridicule, or outright dismissal by authorities. Although the law guarantees equality before the law, the social infrastructure required to invoke that protection remains locked behind a patriarchal wall that refuses to acknowledge men as potential victims of either female or male perpetrators.⁸

This disparity extends beyond legal recognition and into institutional practice. While official workplace harassment figures indicate that women account for approximately three-quarters of reported complaints, they simultaneously reveal that hundreds of men have also formally sought legal protection.³

The existence of these complaints alone demonstrates that male victimization is not merely anecdotal but a documented reality. Yet many experts argue that the true scale is likely much larger because prevailing gender norms discourage men from reporting abuse.⁴ Consequently, public policy should focus not on comparing

suffering between genders but on ensuring that every victim has equal access to justice, support, and protection.

If Pakistan is to cultivate a more effective discourse on violence, we must detach vulnerability from gender. First, our educational curricula must begin to challenge the rigid gender norms that suppress emotional expression among young boys and men. Simultaneously, reporting mechanisms must become explicitly inclusive of all genders, ensuring that victims—regardless of sex—feel safe enough to come forward. Furthermore, the expansion of specialized mental health services remains essential to reducing the stigma that currently prevents many survivors from seeking help. Finally, Pakistan must prioritize nationwide research that systematically documents male victimization so that public policy is informed by evidence rather than assumptions.

Acknowledging male victimhood should never be interpreted as diminishing the experiences of women. On the contrary, a justice system that recognizes every victim regardless of gender is ultimately stronger, more credible, and more equitable. Expanding our understanding of victimization does not weaken protections for women—it strengthens the principle that violence itself, irrespective of the victim's gender, deserves equal condemnation and equal legal response.

The cultural stigma that "men don't cry" is more than just a phrase; it is a barrier to justice. It creates a cycle where silence is mistaken for strength, and that perceived strength is then used to justify continued silence. If Pakistan truly seeks to build a society that protects all its citizens, we must broaden our understanding of who is allowed to be a victim. Harassment and abuse are not gender-exclusive, neither are the perpetrators. We must reach a point where suffering is acknowledged not because it conforms to a familiar narrative, but because it is real. Until then, we will continue to overlook hidden wounds that quietly threaten the social fabric of our society.

Endnotes

1. Syeda Sana Munirkazmi & Anwaar Mohyuddin, *Violence Against Men: A Case Study of Nai Abadi Chakra, Rawalpindi*.
2. Study on Physical and Psychological Violence Against Married Men in District Lower Dir, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.
3. Federal Ombudsman Secretariat for Protection Against Harassment (FOSPAH), **Annual Report 2022–23** (covering workplace harassment complaints from 2011–2023).
4. Male Survivors Partnership, **National Survey on Attitudes Toward Male Harassment**, 2025.
5. International research on male survivors of sexual assault and PTSD (studies referenced in your research summary).
6. **Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan**, Article 25 (Equality of Citizens).
7. Relevant Provincial Domestic Violence Acts and applicable provisions of Pakistani law concerning emotional and psychological abuse.
8. Discussion based on the constitutional guarantee of equality, FOSPAH reporting data, and barriers to reporting identified by the Male Survivors Partnership survey.

References

- Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan. Article 25 (Equality of Citizens).
- Federal Ombudsman Secretariat for Protection Against Harassment (FOSPAH). *Annual Report 2022–23*.
- Male Survivors Partnership. *National Survey on Attitudes Toward Male Harassment*. 2025.
- Munirkazmi, Syeda Sana & Mohyuddin, Anwaar. *Violence Against Men: A Case Study of Nai Abadi Chakra, Rawalpindi*.
- Study on Physical and Psychological Violence Against Married Men in District Lower Dir, Khyber Pakhtunkhwa.
- Pakistan Penal Code and relevant Provincial Domestic Violence legislation.
- International literature on male survivors of sexual assault, PTSD, anxiety, and psychological trauma.

About the Author

I am **Anaya Awais**, a 17-year-old A-Level student from Rawalpindi. I divide my time between coding, reading, and volunteering through internships, experiences that first drew my attention to the gaps within Pakistan's social and legal policies. I do not simply want to discuss these issues—I want to understand the legislative realities behind them and examine why our current systems continue to fail many victims. My goal is to contribute to a national conversation that is guided by evidence, legal reform, and equal access to justice for all.

My photograph is attached separately with the email.

I confirm that this article and the accompanying photograph have not been published elsewhere or submitted to any other publication.